demning Russia for the Ukraine invasion and pushing for cessation of war and a return to dialogue and diplomacy was seen as a breakthrough.

Modi, who played a significant role in evolving that consensus in Bali, seems determined that India proves itself up to the challenge and wants to leave a lasting legacy during its presidency. At the concluding session of the Bali summit, he told the gathering of leaders, "The onus of creating a new order for the post-Covid period now lies on our shoulders. I want to assure you all that India's G20 presidency will be inclusive, ambitious, decisive and action-oriented. Together, we will make G20 a catalyst for global change." If the Indonesian presidency was about 'Recover Together, Recover Stronger', India's theme is 'One Earth, One Family, One Future', which, an official says, reflects how nations need to unite and jointly handle the multiple stresses the world finds itself up against.

The Indian government is pulling out all the stops to make its presidency among the most successful ever. Starting this month and till it passes the gavel to Brazil in December 2023, India will organise over 200 G20 meetings across 56 locations in the country—from Srinagar in the north to Thiruvananthapuram in the south and from the Rann of Kutch in the west to Kohima in the east. All 28 states and eight Union territories have been roped in to organise these meetings, which includes sprucing up venues, ensuring adequate hotel rooms and transport. The G20 meetings are organised along two main tracks—the finance track consisting of eight workstreams that will have 40 meetings, and the other headed by its Sherpa and consisting of 13 working groups that will have 60 meetings. There will be 15 high-level ministerial meetings, including two at the foreign and finance ministers' levels. In addition, there are 12 engagement groups led by civil society organisations in the fields of business, science, gender issues and in what is India's addition—start-ups. They will have 50-odd meetings. In addition, 25 seminars and workshops have been planned (see *Firing on All Cylinders*).

MAKING IT AN 'INCREDIBLE G20'

India intends to leverage these events to reaffirm its global heft in the domestic arena. The convention centre at Pragati Maidan in Delhi is being renovated for the main leaders' summit to be held in September 2023. Traditionally, the summit is held in November, since December 1 is when the successor country takes over the presidency. But pollution levels being extremely high in the capital during that month, the government thought it wise to advance it. The new centre will accommodate over 7,000 delegates, and will have a special floor for the G20 leaders' summit. India is pushing for the largest-

WHAT'S ON THE AGENDA?

India will have to address the following 10 crucial issues during its G20 presidency



AFP

1 UKRAINE WAR

The Russian invasion of Ukraine has triggered a food and energy crisis. At the 2022 G20 summit in Bali, India played a key role in shaping the communique that condemned the war by quoting the UN General Assembly resolution on it. As chair of G20, India now has a bigger role to play in trying for a peace settlement. Even modest success will be a major achievement.

2 A DEBT TRAP

According to the IMF and World Bank, over 80 low- and middle-income group nations face a serious debt crisis, like Pakistan and Sri Lanka in India's neighbourhood. A global recession can



"On the Ukraine war, we need to have the **stamina of a football referee** to keep running from one end to the other"

BALA VENKATESH VARMA
Former ambassador to Russia